

Empiricism - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

EMPIRICISM: ONE EXPERIENTIAL RULE, THREE PRESSURE TESTS

Locke's representative realism → Berkeley's immaterialism → Hume's sceptical naturalism



EXAM ROUTE: thesis → exact doctrine → argument → objection/reply
→ matched comparison → qualified verdict

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge → official current linkage → clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Empiricism - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

RAPID REVISION 1 - The Master Slide - Realism to Idealism to Scepticism

Rapid recall

- Shared premise: no innate ideas; all ideas from experience; mind at birth = "white paper".
- Slide: **Realism (Locke)** -> **Idealism (Berkeley)** -> **Scepticism (Hume)**.
- Engine of the slide: the atomism of impressions - no relation is itself perceived.
- Endpoint: a scepticism nobody can live by -> triggers Kant's a priori rescue.
- **Trap**: do not call it a "collapse"; it is the premise applied consistently.
- **Practice link**: MCQs 1, 2 and 25 test the slide logic; every long-answer PYQ can open with it.

RAPID REVISION 2 - Locke - Theory of Knowledge: Innate Ideas, Tabula Rasa, Sources and Degrees

Rapid recall

- Mind at birth: "white paper, void of all characters" (Essay II.i) - the doctrine labelled *tabula rasa*.
- Two sources: **sensation** (outer) and **reflection** (inner, active).
- Simple ideas (passive) -> complex ideas (modes, substances, relations).
- Three degrees: **intuitive** > **demonstrative** > **sensitive**.
- Refutation lines: no universal consent; no unconscious ideas; genetic account suffices.
- **Trap**: tabula rasa does NOT mean the mind is wholly passive - reflection is an active source.
- **Practice link**: MCQs 3, 4 and 26; PYQ 2022 Q4(c).

RAPID REVISION 3 - Locke - Abstract General Ideas, Nominal and Real Essence

Rapid recall

- Locke: general words work via **abstract general ideas** formed by stripping "circumstances of time and place".
- Canonical admission: the general triangle is "imperfect, that cannot exist" (Essay IV.vii.9) - Berkeley quotes it verbatim.
- Berkeley: no idea can separate what cannot exist apart; a **representative particular** does the work instead.
- Payload: "matter in general" is itself an abstract idea -> meaningless -> immaterialism rests on nominalism.
- **Nominal essence** = the classificatory idea; **real essence** = unknown inner constitution.
- **Trap**: immaterialism depends on the nominalism, not the other way round.
- **Practice link**: MCQs 5, 6 and 27; PYQ 2025 Q4(c).

RAPID REVISION 4 - Locke - Qualities and Substance: Primary, Secondary and the Know-Not-What

Rapid recall

- Primary: extension, figure, motion, solidity, number - in the body, idea resembles.
- Secondary: colour, sound, taste, warmth - powers only; idea resembles nothing.
- Basis: primary qualities are those any body must have however small.
- Substratum: "something I know not what" (Essay II.xxiii.2) - existence granted, nature unknown.
- **Trap**: Locke does NOT deny substance; he denies knowledge of its nature (this is realism, not idealism).
- Berkeley's route in: parity of relativity + "an idea can be like nothing but an idea".
- **Practice link**: MCQs 7, 8 and 28; PYQ 2024 Q2(a).

RAPID REVISION 5 - Locke - Self (Personal Identity) and God

Rapid recall

- Personal identity = **continuity of consciousness (memory)**, not soul, not body.
 - **Prince and cobbler**: consciousness carries the person; the body carries only the "man".
 - Identity is **forensic** - tied to moral responsibility.
 - Objections: **circularity** (Butler) and **transitivity/Brave Officer** (Reid); repair via overlapping chains.
 - Locke's God: **demonstrative** cosmological-style proof (something from nothing is impossible).
 - **Trap**: the criterion is sameness of consciousness, not sameness of soul-substance.
 - **Practice link**: MCQs 9, 10 and 29; PYQ 2021 Q1(d).
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RAPID REVISION 6 - Berkeley - Immaterialism, Esse Est Percipi and the Reconstructed Arguments

Rapid recall

- **esse est percipi** (Principles 3) - for sensible things only; Latin is Berkeley's own.
 - Five arguments: **semantic, likeness, parity, master, continuity**.
 - Collapse: primary qualities are as mind-dependent as secondary -> matter has nothing to be.
 - Master Argument's weakness: scope / use-mention confusion (Russell, Prior, Gallois).
 - Reality = **spirits + ideas**; matter is an empty abstract word.
 - **Trap**: Berkeley denies *matter*, not the *external world*; tables are real ideas sustained by God.
 - **Practice link**: MCQs 11, 12 and 30; PYQs 2021 Q1(c), 2018 Q3(a), 2024 Q2(a).
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RAPID REVISION 7 - Berkeley - Spirits, God, Common Sense; Moore and Russell React

Rapid recall

- Reality = spirits + ideas; **self is real** (active), known by **notion**, not idea.
 - **God** causes the involuntary orderly ideas and sustains unperceived things.
 - Berkeley is **anti-sceptical**: the materialist, not he, breeds doubt.
 - Moore: act of awareness is not its object -> common-sense realism.
 - Russell: logical constructions from sense-data -> mind-independent structure.
 - **Difference**: Moore keeps ordinary objects; Russell analyses them into constructions.
 - **Trap**: do not say Berkeley "denies the world" or "is a sceptic".
 - **Practice link**: MCQs 13, 14 and 31; PYQ 2018 Q3(a).
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RAPID REVISION 8 - Hume - Impressions and Ideas, the Fork, Dissolved Substance and the Bundle Self

Rapid recall

- **Impressions** (vivid) -> **ideas** (faint copies); **Copy Principle** tests meaning.
 - **Fork**: relations of ideas (a priori, necessary) vs matters of fact (a posteriori, contingent).
 - No impression of **substance** -> material and spiritual substance are fictions.
 - **Bundle self**: "a bundle or collection of different perceptions... in perpetual flux".
 - **Appendix retraction**: Hume cannot say what unites the bundle.
 - **Kant**: "I think" as **transcendental unity of apperception** - a formal condition, not a soul.
 - **Trap**: bundle theory denies an *owner*, not the perceptions themselves.
 - **Practice link**: MCQs 15, 16 and 32; PYQs 2018 Q1(a), 2020 Q2(a).
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RAPID REVISION 9 - Hume - Causation: Constant Conjunction, Custom and the Impression of Reflection

Rapid recall

- Observed: priority + contiguity + **constant conjunction**. Not observed: **necessary connexion**.
- Idea of necessity = **impression of reflection** (felt determination of the mind).
- Mechanism = **custom / habit**; expectation is psychological, not rational.
- **Two definitions of cause**: philosophical (regularity) + natural (mental transition) - name both.
- **2019 split**: no necessity in objects; a subjective necessity in the mind.
- **Trap**: Hume relocates causation's necessity; he does not deny causal inference.
- **Practice link**: MCQs 17-20, 25, 26; PYQs 2023 Q2(a), 2021 Q1(e), 2019 Q4(b), 2025 Q2(c).

RAPID REVISION 10 - Hume - Induction, Mitigated Scepticism, God; and the Empiricist-to-Idealist Map

Rapid recall

- **Induction dilemma**: UP is neither demonstrable (no contradiction) nor provable by experience (circular) -> custom.
- Replies: **Kant** (synthetic a priori), **Popper** (no induction), **Strawson** (dissolves the demand).
- **Mitigated scepticism**: modest, evidence-proportioned enquiry - not Pyrrhonian suspension.
- **Hume's God**: causal/design proofs fail; natural theology collapses into causal scepticism.
- **Berkeley (subjective) vs Hegel (absolute)**: ideas in minds vs Geist's self-development - differ in kind.
- ANALYSIS: **CA anchor**: ML operationalises inductive habit but neither proves necessity nor solves the logical problem (IIARD 2026, labelled application only).
- **Practice link**: MCQs 21-24, 27; PYQs 2024 Q2(a), 2022 Q4(c).

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 40 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-24 are core coverage across all ten subtopics; Questions 25-40 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D ten times.

MCQ 1

Which sequence best captures the internal logic ('slide') of British Empiricism?

A. Locke's representative realism -> Berkeley's subjective idealism -> Hume's mitigated scepticism
B. Berkeley's idealism -> Locke's realism -> Hume's scepticism
C. Hume's scepticism -> Locke's realism -> Berkeley's idealism
D. Locke's idealism -> Berkeley's realism -> Hume's dogmatism

Correct answer: A - Locke's representative realism -> Berkeley's subjective idealism -> Hume's mitigated scepticism

Explanation: Each thinker takes the shared premise (all ideas from experience) one step further; the movement runs realism -> idealism -> scepticism.

MCQ 2

The single premise said to drive the empiricist slide is:

A. that God exists and sustains ideas
B. that all ideas derive from experience
C. the primary/secondary quality distinction
D. the doctrine of innate ideas

Correct answer: B - that all ideas derive from experience

Explanation: The shared starting point is experience as the sole source of ideas; the atomism of impressions then forces the slide toward scepticism.

MCQ 3

Locke's central objection to innate ideas is that:

A. they are morally corrupting B. they contradict the existence of God C. universal consent fails and an unperceived idea 'in the mind' is a contradiction D. Descartes never actually held them

Correct answer: C - universal consent fails and an unperceived idea 'in the mind' is a contradiction

Explanation: Children and 'idiots' show no awareness of the alleged principles, and Locke stipulates that to be in the mind is to be perceived, ruling out unnoticed innate content.

MCQ 4

For Locke, the two 'fountains' of all ideas are:

A. intuition and demonstration B. impressions and ideas C. primary and secondary qualities D. sensation and reflection

Correct answer: D - sensation and reflection

Explanation: Sensation (the outer world) and reflection (the mind observing its own operations) supply every idea; the mind at birth is a tabula rasa.

MCQ 5

Locke's 'degrees of knowledge', ordered from most to least certain, are:

A. intuitive, demonstrative, sensitive B. sensitive, demonstrative, intuitive C. demonstrative, intuitive, sensitive D. intuitive, sensitive, demonstrative

Correct answer: A - intuitive, demonstrative, sensitive

Explanation: Intuitive (immediate) is most certain, demonstrative proceeds via intervening ideas, and sensitive knowledge of particular existents is least certain but still reliable.

MCQ 6

Locke's doctrine of abstract general ideas claims that the mind forms a general idea by:

A. denying that general words have any meaning B. omitting the particular differences of particular ideas (e.g. of 'triangle') C. recollecting an innate universal D. perceiving the real essence directly

Correct answer: B - omitting the particular differences of particular ideas (e.g. of 'triangle')

Explanation: Locke's abstraction leaves out differentiating particulars to yield a general idea - the very doctrine Berkeley later destroys.

MCQ 7

For Locke, the 'real essence' of a natural substance such as gold is:

A. the nominal definition we use to classify it B. an abstract general idea in the mind C. its unknown internal constitution, from which its observable properties flow D. identical with its secondary qualities

Correct answer: C - its unknown internal constitution, from which its observable properties flow

Explanation: Nominal essence is the known sorting idea; real essence is the unknown microstructure - unknowable for substances, which is Locke's epistemic humility.

MCQ 8

Which set correctly lists Locke's primary qualities?

A. colour, sound, taste B. warmth, smell, colour C. beauty, value, purpose D. extension, figure, motion, solidity, number

Correct answer: D - extension, figure, motion, solidity, number

Explanation: Primary qualities are inseparable from body and our ideas resemble them; secondary qualities (colour, sound, taste) are only powers to produce sensations.

MCQ 9

Locke's 'substratum' is best described as:

A. a 'something I know not what' that supports qualities but is itself unknown B. a bundle of perceptions in flux C. God's idea of the object D. the real essence, fully known

Correct answer: A - a 'something I know not what' that supports qualities but is itself unknown

Explanation: Locke grants that substance exists but denies knowledge of its nature; Berkeley turns this admitted emptiness into a weapon against matter.

MCQ 10

Locke locates personal identity in:

A. the same immaterial soul-substance B. continuity of consciousness (memory) C. the same living body D. a divine decree

Correct answer: B - continuity of consciousness (memory)

Explanation: Identity is neither soul nor body but sameness of consciousness; Locke calls the term 'forensic' because it fixes accountability.

MCQ 11

The prince-and-cobbler thought experiment is designed to show that:

A. bodies never really change B. memory is fundamentally unreliable C. the person follows the consciousness, not the body D. the soul is the true criterion of identity

Correct answer: C - the person follows the consciousness, not the body

Explanation: Transfer the prince's consciousness into the cobbler's body and the person is the prince, though the 'man' is the cobbler - identity tracks consciousness.

MCQ 12

Locke's proof of God's existence is:

A. purely innate knowledge B. a direct sense perception of God C. a version of the ontological argument D. a demonstrative argument from the impossibility of something coming from nothing

Correct answer: D - a demonstrative argument from the impossibility of something coming from nothing

Explanation: Locke reasons that he exists and nothing can come from nothing, so there must be an eternal, most powerful and most knowing being - a cosmological-style demonstration.

MCQ 13

'Esse est percipi', correctly read, means:

A. for sensible things, to exist is to be perceived B. nothing exists unless I personally am looking at it C. there is no external world whatsoever D. only God exists and the world is illusion

Correct answer: A - for sensible things, to exist is to be perceived

Explanation: The formula applies to sensible things (ideas), which God sustains when no finite mind perceives them; it does not deny the external world.

MCQ 14

Berkeley's 'likeness' principle states that:

A. our ideas resemble material substances B. an idea can be like nothing but an idea C. primary qualities resemble objects but secondary do not D. God resembles the finite mind

Correct answer: B - an idea can be like nothing but an idea

Explanation: If an idea can resemble only another idea, no idea can picture an unperceiving material quality, so Locke's resemblance thesis collapses.

MCQ 15

Berkeley's 'Master Argument' is standardly criticised for:

A. covertly denying the existence of God B. presupposing innate ideas C. a scope / use-mention confusion between the act and the object of conceiving D. relying on constant conjunction

Correct answer: C - a scope / use-mention confusion between the act and the object of conceiving

Explanation: Russell, Prior and Gallois note that conceiving *that* X is unconceived is coherent, even though conceiving X 'as unconceived by me' is not.

MCQ 16

Berkeley's parity (collapse) argument concludes that:

A. only primary qualities are genuinely real B. secondary qualities are objective after all C. matter is unknowable but nonetheless real D. primary qualities are as mind-dependent as secondary, so matter has nothing left to be

Correct answer: D - primary qualities are as mind-dependent as secondary, so matter has nothing left to be

Explanation: The relativities Locke used to subjectivise secondary qualities apply equally to the primary, dragging all qualities into mind-dependence.

MCQ 17

Berkeley holds that we know spirits (minds) by:

A. a notion, because ideas are passive and cannot picture an active mind B. an idea copied from a prior impression C. direct sense perception of the soul D. an innate intuition implanted by God

Correct answer: A - a notion, because ideas are passive and cannot picture an active mind

Explanation: Ideas are passive and inert; the active self and other spirits are grasped by a 'notion', not by an idea - an asymmetry central to Berkeley's system.

MCQ 18

For Berkeley, the continuity of objects when no human perceives them is secured by:

A. an underlying material substance B. God's constant perception C. physical forces described by natural law D. the bundle of perceptions

Correct answer: B - God's constant perception

Explanation: Involuntary, orderly ideas require an active cause; God perceives and sustains them, so the tree in the quad does not blink out when unobserved by us.

MCQ 19

Moore's refutation of idealism turns on distinguishing:

A. primary from secondary qualities B. relations of ideas from matters of fact C. the act of awareness from its object D. impressions from ideas

Correct answer: C - the act of awareness from its object

Explanation: The awareness of blue is not identical with blue; 'esse is percipi' illegitimately fuses the sensing and the sensed.

MCQ 20

The key difference between Moore's and Russell's reactions to Berkeley is that:

A. Russell accepts idealism while Moore rejects it B. Moore uses logical analysis while Russell trusts common sense C. their methods are effectively identical D. Moore defends ordinary objects by direct realism, whereas Russell reconstructs objects as logical constructions from sense-data

Correct answer: D - Moore defends ordinary objects by direct realism, whereas Russell reconstructs objects as logical constructions from sense-data

Explanation: Both resist idealism, but the method differs in kind: Moore keeps ordinary objects; Russell analyses them into constructions seeking mind-independent structure.

MCQ 21

Hume's Copy Principle states that:

A. every simple idea is a faint copy of a prior simple impression B. every impression is a copy of an idea C. all ideas are innate and uncopied D. complex ideas cannot be analysed into simples

Correct answer: A - every simple idea is a faint copy of a prior simple impression

Explanation: The principle grounds Hume's test of meaning: for any term, ask from what impression its idea is derived; if none, the term is a fiction.

MCQ 22

On Hume's Fork, 'the sun will rise tomorrow' is:

- A. a relation of ideas, necessarily true
- B. a matter of fact, whose contrary is always conceivable
- C. strictly meaningless
- D. an analytic truth like 'a bachelor is unmarried'

Correct answer: B - a matter of fact, whose contrary is always conceivable

Explanation: Its denial implies no contradiction, so it is contingent and a posteriori; only propositions like '2+2=4' are necessary relations of ideas.

MCQ 23

Hume's bundle theory of the self is qualified by his Appendix admission that:

- A. the self is an immaterial substance after all
- B. perceptions themselves do not exist
- C. he cannot explain the principle that unites the successive perceptions
- D. memory is an innate faculty

Correct answer: C - he cannot explain the principle that unites the successive perceptions

Explanation: Having denied both a substance and any real connexion, Hume finds nothing left to bind the bundle - 'all my hopes vanish'.

MCQ 24

Applying the Copy Principle to substance, Hume concludes that:

- A. material substance is real but spiritual substance is not
- B. spiritual substance is real but material substance is not
- C. substance is the substratum, known by intuition
- D. there is no impression of substance, so both material and spiritual substance are fictions

Correct answer: D - there is no impression of substance, so both material and spiritual substance are fictions

Explanation: Only impressions of qualities are ever found; with no impression of an underlying support, substance in both forms is a fiction of the imagination.

Remedial MCQ 25

Remedial: the precise content of the claim 'Hume denies causation' is that Hume denies:

- A. the idea of necessary connexion in the objects, not the practice of causal inference
- B. that anything whatever causes anything else
- C. the existence of constant conjunction
- D. the existence of the external world

Correct answer: A - the idea of necessary connexion in the objects, not the practice of causal inference

Explanation: Custom compels us to infer effects from causes; what Hume denies is an objective, perceivable necessary connexion in the objects themselves.

Remedial MCQ 26

Remedial: for Hume the idea of necessary connexion is copied from:

- A. an impression of sensation of a power residing in objects
- B. an impression of reflection - the mind's felt determination to pass from A to B
- C. an innate category of the understanding
- D. a relation of ideas grasped a priori

Correct answer: B - an impression of reflection - the mind's felt determination to pass from A to B

Explanation: Repetition changes the mind, not the objects; the felt determination is the source of the idea, and it yields Hume's two definitions of cause.

Remedial MCQ 27

Remedial: Hume's problem of induction shows that the Uniformity Principle can be justified:

- A. by demonstration alone
- B. by experience alone, and non-circularly
- C. neither demonstratively (nature changing implies no contradiction) nor experientially (that is circular)
- D. by an a priori category supplied by the understanding

Correct answer: C - neither demonstratively (nature changing implies no contradiction) nor experientially (that is circular)

Explanation: Hence induction rests on custom/habit, not reason; Kant's a priori is a later reply, not Hume's own solution.

Remedial MCQ 28

Remedial: the 'parity of reasoning' objection to Locke's quality distinction is that:

A. primary qualities are more real than secondary ones B. secondary qualities do resemble objects C. the distinction is safely grounded in real essence D. the relativities that subjectivise secondary qualities apply equally to the primary ones

Correct answer: D - the relativities that subjectivise secondary qualities apply equally to the primary ones

Explanation: Berkeley concludes that either all qualities are mind-dependent or none are; the resemblance version of the distinction cannot survive.

Remedial MCQ 29

Remedial: Reid's 'Brave Officer' objection shows that Locke's memory criterion can fail to be:

A. transitive B. forensic C. conscious D. bodily

Correct answer: A - transitive

Explanation: The general remembers the officer and the officer the flogged boy, but the general not the boy; overlapping-chains repair restores the required transitivity.

Remedial MCQ 30

Remedial: it is a mistake to call Berkeley a sceptic because:

A. he affirms the reality of material substance B. his idealism is explicitly anti-sceptical - the materialist, not he, breeds doubt C. he denies the existence of God D. he denies that we perceive anything at all

Correct answer: B - his idealism is explicitly anti-sceptical - the materialist, not he, breeds doubt

Explanation: By removing the unknowable material world Berkeley claims certainty; sensible things are real ideas, sustained in being by God.

Remedial MCQ 31

Remedial: Berkeley's subjective idealism differs from Hegel's absolute idealism in that:

A. the two positions are essentially identical B. Berkeley, not Hegel, posits the self-development of Geist C. Berkeley makes reality ideas in finite and divine minds, whereas Hegel makes it the dialectical self-development of Absolute Spirit D. Hegel denies that any minds exist

Correct answer: C - Berkeley makes reality ideas in finite and divine minds, whereas Hegel makes it the dialectical self-development of Absolute Spirit

Explanation: They differ in kind, not degree: Hegel's Absolute is the world's self-unfolding substance, not 'Berkeley writ large'.

Remedial MCQ 32

Remedial: the clearly-labelled contemporary application of Hume's problem of induction to machine learning holds that ML prediction:

A. proves a necessary connexion between events B. solves Hume's logical problem of induction C. removes any need for the Uniformity Principle D. operationalises inductive expectation but neither establishes necessity nor solves the logical problem

Correct answer: D - operationalises inductive expectation but neither establishes necessity nor solves the logical problem

Explanation: Distributional shift restates Hume's point; the anchor (IIARD 2026) is a contemporary application, not doctrinal proof, and invents no statistics.

Remedial MCQ 33

Locke's sensitive knowledge most directly concerns:

A. the present existence of particular external things B. necessary relations among abstract ideas C. an innate awareness of God D. the real essence of natural kinds

Correct answer: A - present particular existence

Explanation: Locke ranks sensitive knowledge below intuitive and demonstrative knowledge, but he still treats present sensory assurance of particular external things as knowledge rather than mere probability.

Remedial MCQ 34

For Berkeley, the active cause that perceives and wills is:

A. an abstract material substratum B. a spirit C. a passive idea D. a primary quality

Correct answer: B - a spirit

Explanation: Ideas are passive objects of awareness. Finite and infinite spirits are active perceivers and causes, although a spirit is known by notion rather than presented as another idea.

Remedial MCQ 35

Hume's missing shade of blue is best treated as:

A. proof that impressions never precede ideas B. a relation of ideas C. a narrow acknowledged qualification to the Copy Principle D. a demonstration of material substance

Correct answer: C - a narrow acknowledged qualification

Explanation: Hume allows that an experienced sequence of shades might enable imagination to supply one missing shade. The exception qualifies an exceptionless formulation without destroying the principle's normal critical use.

Remedial MCQ 36

Mitigated scepticism recommends:

A. suspending every belief required for action B. treating custom as demonstrative proof C. accepting only mathematical propositions D. limiting inquiry and proportioning belief to evidence and human capacities

Correct answer: D - disciplined, proportioned belief

Explanation: Hume rejects excessive scepticism as practically and dialectically unstable. Mitigated scepticism retains common life, probability and inquiry while restraining speculative claims.

Remedial MCQ 37

Locke's nominal essence is:

A. the abstract idea associated with a general name and used for classification B. the hidden microstructure known with demonstrative certainty C. the material substratum apart from every quality D. the continuity of consciousness

Correct answer: A - the classificatory abstract idea

Explanation: The real essence is the usually unknown internal constitution; the nominal essence is the abstract idea by which speakers sort particulars under a name.

Remedial MCQ 38

Berkeley explains the stable continuity of sensible order primarily through:

A. unperceived material particles B. God's active causation and perception C. each human imagination independently creating objects D. the resemblance of ideas to matter

Correct answer: B - divine ordering

Explanation: Objects do not vanish when no human looks. Their stable, involuntary and shared sensory order is grounded in the infinite spirit rather than in matter or finite imagination.

Remedial MCQ 39

Why can past inductive success not non-circularly justify induction for Hume?

A. Relations of ideas are always false B. Effects never follow causes C. The inference from past success to future reliability already assumes uniformity D. Custom supplies a demonstrative proof

Correct answer: C - the proposed proof already uses induction

Explanation: Experience can show only that induction worked in observed cases. Extending that success to unobserved cases presupposes that the future will resemble the past.

Remedial MCQ 40

Which statement best captures Locke's distinction among person, human being and substance?

A. All three are identical because memory belongs to the same body B. Person means immaterial soul, while human being means a collection of ideas C. Substance alone determines forensic responsibility D. Person follows consciousness, human being follows organism, and substance names the bearer

Correct answer: D - three different identity questions

Explanation: The prince-and-cobbler case separates continuity of consciousness from continuity of the human organism and from sameness of an underlying material or immaterial substance.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

EXAM APPLICATION 1 - The Master Slide - Realism to Idealism to Scepticism

How the slide is examined

- The slide itself is rarely the *whole* question, but it is the **frame** every long answer should open with. A 20-marker such as **2024 Q2(a)** (does rejecting Locke's primary qualities push Berkeley to idealism?) is really a demand to walk one step of the slide and then contrast it with Hegel's very different idealism.
- **2018 Q1(a)** (are "the Sun will rise" and " $2+2=4$ " of the same necessity?) is the slide's epistemic engine - Hume's Fork - stated as a single-part question.

10-mark use: open by naming the shared premise, place the thinker on the slide, then answer the specific demand.

15/20-mark use: use the slide as the spine - state the premise, show the thinker taking it one step further than his predecessor, then deliver the specific comparison or criticism the directive asks for.

Directive trap: "Bring out / Trace" wants a **development**, not three parallel summaries. Show each thinker as the previous one made consistent.

EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Locke - Theory of Knowledge: Innate Ideas, Tabula Rasa, Sources and Degrees

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2022 Q4(c), 15 marks:** *Why and how does Locke refute innate ideas? Elucidate the nature and source of knowledge in Locke's epistemology.* This is the stock content of this subtopic - the refutation PLUS the positive account (tabula rasa, sensation/reflection, simple/complex, degrees).
- **2023 Q2(c) (Rationalism-owned)** asks Descartes' innate ideas and Locke's refutation - the same material seen from the rival side; useful cross-link, but the primary owner there is Rationalism.

10-mark: state the two-channel account -> name one refuting argument -> one qualification. **15-mark:** refutation (consent, no-unconscious-idea, genetic account) -> positive account (sources + simple/complex + degrees) -> the dispositional-innatism qualification. **Directive trap:** "Elucidate" demands the *derivation*, not synonyms for "blank slate". Give the mechanism (sensation/reflection -> simple -> complex) and at least one degree of knowledge.

EXAM APPLICATION 3 - Locke - Abstract General Ideas, Nominal and Real Essence

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2025 Q4(c), 15 marks:** *Explain Berkeley's doctrine of nominalism and his refutation of Abstract ideas.* You cannot answer this without Locke's positive doctrine first - state what Berkeley is refuting, then the refutation, then the metaphysical payload (matter as an abstract idea, hence meaningless).
- Cross-link: nominal/real essence recurs in any "substance" or "classification" answer.

15-mark spine: Locke's abstraction (why he needs it; the triangle admission) -> Berkeley's numbered refutation (separation of the inseparable is impossible; the triangle is self-contradictory) -> positive replacement (representative particular) -> payload (matter is an abstract idea) -> qualification (determinable Locke survives). **Directive trap:** "Explain" here means *exhibit the derivation*; do not merely assert "Berkeley rejected abstract ideas".

EXAM APPLICATION 4 - Locke - Qualities and Substance: Primary, Secondary and the Know-Not-What

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2024 Q2(a), 20 marks:** *Is rejection of Locke's notion of primary qualities instrumental in Berkeley's leaning towards idealism? In this context also discuss how subjective idealism is different from the absolute idealism proposed by Hegel.* This subtopic supplies the first half - you must show that once resemblance/primary status falls, "matter" loses its last foothold.
- Substratum content recurs in any "Locke on substance" or cross-thinker "substance" comparison.

20-mark spine: state the distinction and the substratum -> Berkeley's parity + likeness attack -> therefore matter has nothing left to be -> the idealist turn -> then pivot to the required Hegel contrast (subjective vs absolute idealism, handled fully in subtopic 10). **Directive trap:** the question is "instrumental?" - you must **judge**, not just narrate; answer yes-with-qualification (it removes the last resemblance, but Berkeley's nominalism does the deeper work).

EXAM APPLICATION 5 - Locke - Self (Personal Identity) and God

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2021 Q1(d), 10 marks:** *Examine the concept of personal identity by Locke.* "Examine" = state the doctrine AND test it - so the memory criterion PLUS the circularity/Brave-Officer objection are both required.
- Locke's God feeds any "empiricist proofs of God" or cross-paper theism comparison, and contrasts sharply with Hume's demolition of the same causal principle.

10-mark spine: memory-continuity thesis -> not soul, not body (prince-cobbler) -> forensic point -> close on the circularity objection's force. **Directive trap:** a bare exposition scores low on "examine"; the objection is the differentiator - name Butler/Reid and the Brave Officer.

EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Berkeley - Immaterialism, Esse Est Percipi and the Reconstructed Arguments

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2021 Q1(c), 10 marks:** *"Sensible things are those only which are immediately perceived by sense."* Explain Berkeley's theory of knowledge with reference to the above statement. This is the semantic argument stated as a quotation - locate the line, give immediate-perception, then esse est percipi.
- **2018 Q3(a), 20 marks:** *How does Berkeley establish that Mind and its ideas alone are real...?* - demands the full establishment (the arguments), then Moore/Russell (subtopic 7).
- **2024 Q2(a), 20 marks:** the primary-qualities route into idealism (parity/collapse argument).

10-mark: name the relevant argument, give it in three or four lines, close with the anti-sceptical intent. **20-mark:** name and reconstruct the arguments, add the strongest objection (master-argument scope error), then adjudicate. **Directive trap:** "Explain / Elucidate" wants the derivation of the arguments, not the slogan in synonyms.

EXAM APPLICATION 7 - Berkeley - Spirits, God, Common Sense; Moore and Russell React

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2018 Q3(a), 20 marks:** *How does Berkeley establish that Mind and its ideas alone are real? How do Moore and Russell react... Do you find any difference...?* Three demands: establish (arguments + God), Moore vs Berkeley, Russell vs Berkeley, then the Moore-Russell difference.
- Berkeley's anti-sceptical claim is the pivot for any "is Berkeley a sceptic?" trap.

20-mark spine: establish immaterialism (name the arguments; spirits by notion; God) -> Moore's act/object refutation -> Russell's logical-construction alternative -> adjudicate the difference (direct realism vs analysis) -> verdict.

Directive trap: the marks live in the **comparison** - a script that reacts to Berkeley but never separates Moore from Russell forfeits the final third.

EXAM APPLICATION 8 - Hume - Impressions and Ideas, the Fork, Dissolved Substance and the Bundle Self

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2018 Q1(a), 10 marks:** *Are "the Sun will rise tomorrow" and " $2+2=4$ " of the same necessity for Hume?* Pure Fork: one is a matter of fact (contingent, deniable), the other a relation of ideas (necessary) - **not** the same necessity.
- **2020 Q2(a), 20 marks:** *"I never can catch myself... without perception..." How does this problematize personal identity? How does Kant deal with it?* Bundle self -> Appendix worry -> Kant's transcendental unity.

10-mark (Fork): define the two prongs -> place each proposition -> state the asymmetry (deny " $2+2=4$ " -> contradiction; deny sunrise -> merely improbable, never impossible). **20-mark (self):** Copy Principle -> no impression of self -> bundle -> Appendix confession -> Kant's formal unity as reply -> verdict on atomism. **Directive trap:** 2018 wants a **distinction**, not "both are certain"; do not collapse relations of ideas into matters of fact.

EXAM APPLICATION 9 - Hume - Causation: Constant Conjunction, Custom and the Impression of Reflection

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2023 Q2(a), 20 marks:** *Hume's argument that causality is nothing but habit or custom - critically analyse.* Full negative + positive movement, two definitions, then critique via the presuppositions.
- **2021 Q1(e), 10 marks:** the causation analysis in compressed form.
- **2019 Q4(b), 15 marks:** *is there any element of necessity?* - the objects-no / mind-yes split.
- **2025 Q2(c), 15 marks:** Hume's refutation of the causal relation (pairs with Kant's reply - subtopic 10 supplies the Kant half).

20-mark spine: observed elements -> no impression of power -> impression of reflection -> custom/habit -> the two definitions -> presuppositions -> critical verdict. **Directive trap:** "critically analyse" forbids pure exposition; the two definitions plus one named presupposition-attack are the grade-defining content.

EXAM APPLICATION 10 - Hume - Induction, Mitigated Scepticism, God; and the Empiricist-to-Idealist Map

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2024 Q2(a), 20 marks:** the primary-qualities route into idealism PLUS *subjective idealism versus Hegel's absolute idealism* - use the canonical in-kind distinction (Geist's self-development vs ideas in minds).
- **2022 Q4(c), 15 marks:** Hume's scepticism / limits of empiricist knowledge - mitigated scepticism is the positive close.
- Induction underlies the causation cluster (2023, 2019, 2025) whenever the answer must reach the Uniformity Principle.

20-mark spine (2024): parity/collapse removes matter -> immaterialism -> then pivot: Berkeley subjective (ideas in finite + divine minds) vs Hegel absolute (Geist's dialectical self-development) -> verdict that they differ in kind.

Directive trap: the comparison, not the exposition of Berkeley, carries the second half - never reduce Hegel to "Berkeley writ large".

Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Western Philosophy Paper I bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 12 Empiricism-owned questions; the three 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism' questions are Quine-Strawson owned and are excluded here.
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: claim -> named text/example -> analysis -> qualification.
- MCQs: 24 core plus 16 remedial, exactly 40, strict A-B-C-D rotation eight times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Contemporary linkage: the machine-learning-and-induction anchor is available in the main session; it is not doctrinal proof and no statistic is invented.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is exact verified PYQs -> 24 core MCQs -> 16 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED TEXT/EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION/REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 12 VERIFIED EMPIRICISM QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Western Philosophy Paper I bank for 2018-2025. Empiricism owns exactly 12 primary parts. The three 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism' questions (2021 Q3c, 2024 Q4c, 2025 Q4b) are Quine-Strawson owned and are deliberately excluded despite the shared word 'empiricism'.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: Are the two truths-'The Sun will rise tomorrow' and ' $2+2=4$ ' of the same necessity for Hume? Give reasons in favour of your answer.

Model solution

Thesis (directive: give reasons). No. For Hume the two propositions are certain in *different senses*: " $2+2=4$ " is a **relation of ideas** (necessary), while "the Sun will rise tomorrow" is a **matter of fact** (contingent). Treating them as the same necessity is precisely the confusion Hume's Fork exists to prevent.

Doctrine - Hume's Fork. Every object of human reason is either a *relation of ideas* (known a priori by thought alone; denial is self-contradictory) or a *matter of fact* (known a posteriori; the contrary is always conceivable).

- " $2+2=4$ ": to deny it is to contradict oneself; its necessity is demonstrative and absolute, independent of what exists.
- "The Sun will rise tomorrow": "the Sun will not rise" implies **no** contradiction - it is perfectly conceivable. It cannot be demonstrated; it rests on causal inference, and causal inference rests on constant conjunction plus **custom**,

never on logical necessity.

Analysis. The felt certainty of sunrise is a *psychological* assurance produced by habit and the presupposed uniformity of nature, not a *logical* one. To rank it with " $2+2=4$ " would smuggle demonstrative necessity into a merely probable belief - the very slide from expectation to necessary connexion that Hume diagnoses.

Qualification / verdict. Both may be called "certain" in ordinary speech, but the certainties differ in kind: one is logical and unconditional, the other customary and revisable. Naming the two prongs and applying the conceivability test is the whole answer.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q3(a), 20 marks

Question: How does Berkeley establish that Mind and its ideas alone are real? How do Moore and Russell react to Berkeley's view in this regard? Do you find any difference between Moore's reaction and Russell's one? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Berkeley establishes that only minds and their ideas are real by a **set of arguments**, not a bare slogan; Moore and Russell both reject the result, but by *different methods*, so there is a real difference between their reactions.

How Berkeley establishes it. (1) *Semantic*: sensible things just are collections of immediately perceived ideas, so their being is being perceived (*esse est percipi*). (2) *Likeness*: "an idea can be like nothing but an idea", so no idea can resemble an unperceiving material quality. (3) *Parity/collapse*: every relativity Locke grants for secondary qualities applies to the primary, so all qualities are ideas and matter has nothing left to be. (4) *Master Argument*: one cannot conceive an unconceived object. (5) *Continuity*: the involuntary, orderly ideas of sense require an active cause - the infinite Mind, God. Spirits are known not by ideas (which are passive) but by **notions**.

Moore's reaction. In "The Refutation of Idealism" Moore distinguishes the **act** of awareness from its **object**: the awareness of blue is not identical with blue. Berkeley's inference illegitimately fuses sensing and sensed; once separated, the object need not depend on the act, and common-sense realism stands.

Russell's reaction. Russell also refuses idealism but does not simply trust ordinary objects; he **reconstructs** physical objects by logical analysis as constructions out of sense-data and their relations, seeking mind-independent structure.

Is there a difference? - Yes. Moore keeps ordinary objects through the transparency of sensation (direct realism); Russell replaces ordinary objects with logical constructions. The difference is one of method, not merely emphasis.

Verdict. Both deny that existence collapses into being-perceived. Berkeley's reply - that there is no object over and above the idea - shows the Master Argument to be question-begging, but does not rescue the likeness principle against structural (non-qualitative) resemblance.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q4(b), 15 marks

Question: Is there any element of necessity in causal relations according to Hume? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Yes and no - the answer must **split the locus** of necessity. In the *objects* there is none; in the *mind* there is a genuine but merely psychological necessity.

In objects - no necessity. Applying the Copy Principle, a single instance of causation (one billiard ball striking another) delivers only priority, contiguity and the succession of qualities; no impression of a *power* or *tie* is given, and repetition adds nothing to the objects themselves. So causal necessity is not an objective relation in nature.

In the mind - a subjective necessity. Repetition does change the *mind*: after constant conjunction it is **determined** to pass from the idea of A to the idea of B. That felt determination is an **impression of reflection**, and it is a real, if psychological, necessity - a fact about us, not about things. From it flow the **two definitions** of cause (philosophical: constant conjunction; natural: the mind's transition).

Analysis. Hume therefore does not *abolish* necessity; he **relocates** it from world to mind. The disciplined answer refuses to collapse the two loci - "no necessity in objects" and "a subjective necessity in the mind" are both true.

Verdict. There is necessity in causation for Hume only as projected felt compulsion; objective necessary connexion is a fiction of the imagination. Naming both definitions secures the marks.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: "I never can catch myself at any time without perception, and never can observe anything but the perception." How does this statement by Hume problematize the philosophical notion of personal identity? How does Kant deal with this problem in his Critique of Pure Reason?

Model solution

Thesis. Hume's confession problematizes personal identity by removing any *impression* of a self, leaving only a **bundle**; Kant answers not by restoring a soul but by making the unity of the self a **formal condition** of experience.

How Hume problematizes it. By the Copy Principle every idea needs a source impression. Introspection ("I never can catch myself... without a perception") finds only a flux of particular perceptions, never an impression of a simple, continuing "I". So the self is "nothing but a bundle or collection of different perceptions... in perpetual flux". The ascribed identity is a *fiction* produced by imagination's habits of resemblance and causation. Hume's **Appendix** honestly retracts: he can find no principle that *unites* the successive perceptions.

How Kant deals with it. Kant grants that there is no *empirical intuition* of the self. But the "**I think**" must be *able* to accompany all my representations, as the condition of their belonging to one consciousness - the **transcendental unity of apperception**. This is a formal, a priori condition of unified experience, not an observed inner object and not a Cartesian ego-substance.

Analysis / verdict. Kant concedes Hume's negative point (no impression of a self) while denying his conclusion (therefore no unifying subject). The bundle is the last casualty of an atomism of impressions in which no relation can itself be perceived; Kant's reply targets that atomism, relocating unity from something *found* to something *presupposed*. (The Buddhist anatta parallel may be noted.)

Solved PYQ 5 - 2021 Q1(c), 10 marks

Question: "Sensible things are those only which are immediately perceived by sense." Explain Berkeley's theory of knowledge with reference to the above statement.

Model solution

Thesis. The quoted line states Berkeley's **semantic argument**: since sensible things are *only* what is immediately perceived, their whole being is to be perceived - *esse est percipi*.

Explanation of the theory of knowledge. For Berkeley the immediate objects of sense are **ideas**. What we call a "thing" (an apple, a table) is a stable collection of such immediately perceived ideas - colours, tastes, shapes, sounds. Anything "mediately" inferred behind them (a material substratum) is never itself perceived, so belief in it has no experiential content and is meaningless. Hence, for sensible things, to be is to be perceived; and minds (spirits), which do the perceiving, are known not by ideas but by **notions**.

Anti-sceptical point. Because there is no unperceivable matter behind our ideas, there is no "veil of perception" to breed doubt: we perceive real things *directly* (they are ideas), and God's constant perception secures their continuity.

Verdict. The statement is the compressed form of the whole system: restrict reality to the immediately perceived, and idealism follows without scepticism.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q1(d), 10 marks

Question: Examine the concept of personal identity by Locke.

Model solution

Thesis (directive: examine). Locke's criterion is **continuity of consciousness**, not sameness of soul or body; it is a genuine advance, but the examining eye must expose that memory alone cannot carry the whole weight.

The doctrine. Personal identity consists in the same *consciousness* extended backwards through memory. It is neither sameness of material body (which changes) nor sameness of thinking substance/soul (which could be swapped unnoticed). The **prince and the cobbler** isolate the thesis: transfer the prince's consciousness into the cobbler's body and the *person* of the prince goes with it, though the *man* is the cobbler. Identity is a **forensic** term - it fixes accountability, since we are answerable only for acts we can appropriate as our own.

Examination - objections. (i) **Circularity** (Butler): I can remember only *my own* past experiences, so identity is presupposed before memory can confirm it. (ii) **Transitivity failure** (Reid's **Brave Officer**): the general remembers

the officer, the officer the flogged boy, but the general not the boy; by Locke's rule general = officer = boy yet general is not boy. Repair: **overlapping chains** of memory restore transitivity.

Verdict. Locke rightly detaches the person from both body and soul and ties identity to moral answerability; but memory is at best part of the criterion, and later psychological-continuity theories are repairs of Locke, not replacements.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 Q1(e), 10 marks

Question: "The relation between cause and effect is one of constant conjunction". Examine Hume's criticism of causation in the light of the above statement.

Model solution

Thesis. The statement gives Berkeley-free, purely Humean *objective* definition of cause: all that "cause and effect" denotes in the objects is **constant conjunction** - there is no perceivable necessary connexion.

Hume's criticism, in steps. (1) In any single instance we observe only temporal priority, spatial contiguity and the succession of qualities - never a *power* binding cause to effect. (2) Repetition adds nothing to the objects; the hundredth collision is, in the objects, no different from the first. (3) What repetition changes is the **mind**: after constant conjunction it is *determined* to expect B on seeing A. (4) That felt determination is an **impression of reflection**, the true source of the idea of necessity. (5) Hence the **two definitions** of cause - philosophical (constant conjunction) and natural (the mind's transition).

Analysis. "The relation... is one of constant conjunction" is therefore the *objective* half of the story: necessity is not *in* the relation but **projected** onto it by custom/habit, "the great guide of human life".

Verdict / trap. Hume does not deny that we make causal inferences (custom compels them); he denies the *idea of necessary connexion in objects*. Reading the line as "mere succession" is incomplete - it omits contiguity, priority and the felt necessity.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2022 Q4(c), 15 marks

Question: Why and how does John Locke refute the innate ideas? Elucidate the nature and source of knowledge in Locke's epistemology.

Model solution

Thesis. Locke refutes innate ideas because, once experience is shown to supply every idea, innate content is **unnecessary and unevicenced**; his positive epistemology then derives all knowledge from **sensation and reflection**.

Why he refutes innate ideas. (1) The **universal-consent** argument fails: if principles like identity or "the whole is greater than the part" were innate, all would assent, yet children and "idiots" show no awareness of them. (2) The dispositional rescue ("innate but not yet noticed") is ruled out by Locke's stipulation that "to be in the mind" *is* "to be perceived by the mind" - an unperceived idea in the mind is a contradiction. (3) Innate ideas are in any case **superfluous** once experience can account for the same content.

How - the nature and source of knowledge. The mind at birth is "**white paper, void of all characters**" (*tabula rasa*). Two fountains supply ideas: **sensation** (the outer world) and **reflection** (the mind observing its own operations). **Simple ideas** are received passively; the mind actively combines them into **complex ideas** (modes, substances, relations). Knowledge is the perception of the agreement/disagreement of ideas and comes in **degrees** - *intuitive* (most certain), *demonstrative* (via intervening ideas), *sensitive* (of particular existents, least certain but reliable).

Qualification / verdict. Locke's argument defeats a *naïve* innatism (fully formed conscious principles at birth). It does not touch the **dispositional** innatism that Descartes and Leibniz actually held (Leibniz's "veined marble"). His enduring contribution is the derivation programme - experience as the sole source, with reflection kept as an *active* second source so the mind is not merely passive.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2023 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: Critically analyse Hume's argument that causality is a matter of habit/custom involving psychological principle of association.

Model solution

Thesis (directive: critically analyse). Hume's reduction of causality to habit/custom, powered by the psychological principle of **association**, is unanswerable *as a description of what perception gives* - but it rests on contestable presuppositions, and its verdict must be qualified rather than simply endorsed.

Exposition. Negatively: by the Copy Principle no impression of *power* is found in any single instance (billiard balls, bread nourishing); repetition adds nothing to the objects. **Positively:** repetition determines the **mind** to pass from A to B; this felt determination is an **impression of reflection**. The transition is governed by the principles of **association** - resemblance, contiguity and cause-effect - the "gentle force" that carries the imagination from one idea to the next. Hence the **two definitions** of cause (constant conjunction; mental transition) and the reduction of necessity to custom, "the great guide of human life".

Critical analysis - presuppositions. (P1) the Copy Principle is treated as exceptionless - yet Hume himself concedes the **missing shade of blue**; (P2) causation must be *visible in a single instance* if it is objective at all; (P3) impressions are **atomic and separable**, so no relation is given with its terms; (P4) necessity must be either observed or projected, with no third option such as an inferred theoretical posit. **Kant** attacks exactly this: causality is an a priori **category**, a condition of objective experience, supplying the necessity perception cannot.

Verdict. As phenomenology of the given, Hume is decisive; as metaphysics, his atomism makes lawful, theoretical necessity look illegitimate *by fiat*. The graded position: accept the psychological account, reject the atomist premise that rules out non-observational necessity.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2024 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: Is rejection of Locke's notion of primary qualities instrumental in Berkeley's leaning towards idealism? In this context, also discuss how subjective idealism is different from the absolute idealism proposed by Hegel.

Model solution

Thesis. Yes - with qualification. Rejecting the privileged status of Locke's **primary qualities** removes matter's last foothold and is genuinely *instrumental* in Berkeley's idealism; but Berkeley's **nominalism** does the deeper work. And Berkeley's *subjective* idealism differs **in kind** from Hegel's *absolute* idealism.

The instrumental role. Locke made primary qualities (extension, figure, motion) really resemble our ideas, while secondary qualities were mere powers. Berkeley's **parity argument** shows that every relativity used to subjectivise the secondary (variation with observer, organ, medium) applies equally to the primary (apparent size, shape, motion vary too). So either all qualities are mind-dependent or none are; since Locke concedes it for the secondary, parity drags the primary along. Once no quality is left to inhere in matter, and the likeness principle ("an idea can be like nothing but an idea") blocks resemblance to an unperceiving substratum, "matter" has nothing to be. In this precise sense rejecting primary qualities is instrumental - though the argument is completed only by Berkeley's prior denial of **abstract ideas**.

Subjective vs absolute idealism. *Berkeley:* reality is **ideas in finite and divine minds** - things are mind-dependent, sustained by God's perceiving; existence is being perceived. *Hegel:* reality is the **self-development of Absolute Spirit (Geist) through dialectic** - Mind developing itself as the very substance of the world. So Berkeley's idealism is *subjective* (depends on minds that already exist and perceive), Hegel's is *objective/absolute* (finite minds and world alike are moments in one self-unfolding Absolute).

Verdict. Instrumental, yes, but not sufficient alone; and the two idealisms differ in **kind, not degree** - Hegel's Absolute is not "Berkeley writ large".

Solved PYQ 11 - 2025 Q2(c), 15 marks

Question: Examine Hume's refutation of Causal relation and Kant's response to it.

Model solution

Thesis. Hume refutes the *objective* causal relation by finding no impression of necessary connexion; Kant responds not by observing such a connexion but by making causality an a priori **category** that constitutes objective experience.

Hume's refutation. In any instance we perceive only priority, contiguity and constant conjunction; no *power* or *tie* is given, and repetition adds nothing to the objects. The idea of necessity is copied from an **impression of reflection** - the mind's felt determination to pass from A to B after constant conjunction. Hence necessity is **projected**, not

perceived; causal inference rests on **custom/habit**, and two definitions of cause follow. Extended to induction, the Uniformity Principle can be justified neither demonstratively (its denial is not contradictory) nor experientially (circular).

Kant's response. Awakened by Hume from "dogmatic slumber", Kant concedes that no *impression* of necessity exists, but denies Hume's conclusion. The concept of cause is a **pure concept of the understanding** (a category); the principle "every event has a cause" is a **synthetic a priori** condition without which objective, ordered experience of a temporal world would be impossible. Necessity is real but its seat is the **mind's constitution of objects**, not the objects in themselves (transcendental idealism).

Verdict. Kant meets Hume by relocating necessity from *habit* to the *a priori form* of experience - preserving science's lawfulness while accepting Hume's point that necessity is not read off perception. The unresolved cost is that necessity holds only for phenomena, not things-in-themselves.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2025 Q4(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain Berkeley's doctrine of nominalism and his refutation of Abstract ideas.

Model solution

Thesis. Berkeley's **nominalism** - the denial of **abstract general ideas** - is the indispensable first premise of immaterialism: there is no abstract idea of "matter" or "existence" apart from being perceived.

Refutation of abstract ideas. Against Locke, Berkeley argues that the mind simply **cannot frame** an abstract general idea - for instance, an idea of a triangle that is "neither oblique nor rectangle, equilateral nor scalene, but all and none of these at once". Every idea we actually have is fully **particular** (this determinate colour, this determinate shape). Introspection never yields the indeterminate abstract image Locke's doctrine requires.

How generality is preserved (nominalism). Words are general, not ideas. A **particular** idea becomes general by **representative function** - it *stands for* all other particulars of the same sort. "Triangle" in a proof signifies any triangle because the particular figure drawn represents all; the generality lies in the *use/sign*, not in a special abstract object.

Consequence for immaterialism. Since there is no abstract idea, there is no legitimate abstract idea of **existence unperceived**, nor of a quality existing in an unthinking **substratum**. "Matter" is exposed as an empty abstraction - the very fiction Locke's doctrine of abstraction had made to seem intelligible. So the refutation of abstract ideas clears the ground on which *esse est percipi* is built.

Verdict. Nominalism is not a side-doctrine but the **engine**: destroy abstraction and the abstract idea of matter falls with it. This is why the examiner pairs "nominalism" and "abstract ideas" - they are one movement.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

These are original questions (not from the verified PYQ bank), written in UPSC directive style to drill the same doctrine at 10, 15 and 20 marks. Model solutions follow the claim -> doctrine -> named evidence -> objection/reply -> verdict spine.

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks

Q. "The mind is white paper, void of all characters." Explain Locke's empiricist theory of the source of knowledge and state one difficulty it faces. (Answer in 150 words.)

Model solution. Locke's image denies innate ideas: the mind at birth carries no characters, and every idea enters through two fountains - **sensation** (the outer world) and **reflection** (the mind observing its own operations). Simple ideas are received passively; the mind actively compounds them into complex ideas, and knowledge (the perception of agreement/disagreement of ideas) comes in degrees - intuitive, demonstrative, sensitive. The programme is powerful because it explains conceptual content without innate furniture. **One difficulty:** reflection is an *internal* source whose operations (comparing, willing, doubting) are not obviously given by outer experience, so critics charge that Locke smuggles a non-sensory faculty back in; and Leibniz replies that the "blank paper" is really *veined marble* - dispositions the mind brings to experience. Locke defeats naive innatism but not this dispositional version.

Original Mains 2 - 15 marks

Q. Examine Berkeley's claim that immaterialism defends common sense rather than destroys it. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model solution. Berkeley's paradox is that abolishing matter is meant to *save* ordinary belief. His case has two sides. **Destructive:** the semantic, likeness, parity and master arguments show that a mind-independent material substratum is both unperceivable and unintelligible - "an idea can be like nothing but an idea", and the relativities Locke grants for secondary qualities engulf the primary too. **Constructive:** what remains is exactly the world of ordinary experience - tables, trees, apples - now understood as stable **collections of ideas**. Their existence unperceived by us is secured by **God's** constant perception; their order is the settled way an infinite Spirit produces our involuntary ideas, i.e. the laws of nature. So Berkeley claims to be *anti-sceptical*: it is the *materialist* who breeds doubt by inserting an unknowable world behind the veil of perception. **Examination.** The claim is partly vindicated - Berkeley does keep the perceptible world and rejects the veil. But it is bought with heavy metaphysics: God must do the work matter did, and other minds are known only by analogy, raising a solipsism worry. Samuel Johnson's stone-kicking misses the target (the stone is a real idea), yet Moore's later act/object distinction reopens the question of whether being and being-perceived can be so easily identified. **Verdict:** Berkeley rescues common-sense *objects* while overturning the common-sense *metaphysics* of matter - a defence of ordinary life resting on an extraordinary theology.

Original Mains 3 - 20 marks

Q. "Hume's scepticism about causation is the empiricist premise made consistent, not a failure of empiricism." Critically discuss, and assess Kant's response. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model solution. The statement reads Hume not as breaking empiricism but as **completing** it. Locke admitted an unknowable material substratum; Berkeley dropped matter but kept an active self and God; Hume applies the Copy Principle without exception and finds no impression of **substance**, of a simple **self**, or of **necessary connexion**. On causation the analysis is exact: a single instance yields only priority, contiguity and constant conjunction; repetition changes not the objects but the **mind**, which is *determined* to expect the effect - an **impression of reflection** from which the idea of necessity is copied, yielding the **two definitions** of cause. Induction then has no rational ground: the Uniformity Principle is neither demonstrable nor provable without circularity, so custom, "the great guide of human life", replaces reason. **Critical discussion.** This is consistency, not carelessness - but consistency exposes a premise: the **atomism of impressions**, on which no relation can itself be perceived, so every relation becomes a projection. That premise, not the psychology, is the vulnerable point, and Hume's own **missing shade of blue** already dents the exceptionless Copy Principle. **Kant's response.** Kant concedes there is no impression of necessity yet denies Hume's conclusion: causality is an a priori **category**, a condition of objective experience, so the necessity is real but seated in the mind's constitution of phenomena (the synthetic a priori). **Verdict:** Hume's scepticism is empiricism made rigorous, and it rightly shows the bare premise "all ideas from experience" to be *incomplete*; Kant's reply supplies the missing structure, at the price of confining necessity to appearances.